

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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SESSION NINE

Renewing Your Purpose

Flex session: Day 3 afternoon if there is capacity, otherwise in the 30-day plan

Before you begin

This is the second flex session, and it builds on Session Eight. If you have not done Eight, you can still do this one, but the two belong together: identity first, then purpose. If you are on Day 3, check honestly whether you have the energy for this before Session Ten. If not, it will keep.

A word about what this session is not. It is not a career-change session, a call to a grand mission, or a place to decide whether to leave your job or your ministry. Session Seven's rule stands: no major, irreversible, or high-risk decision is made on a retreat. This session is about something quieter and more durable: where purpose comes from, and how to renew it, or narrow it, when it has drained away into obligation.

Central passage

John 21:15–19

Read it twice. The second time, count the questions and notice what Jesus does not ask.

Teaching

Peter had denied Jesus three times on the night of the arrest. After the resurrection, on a beach in Galilee, after breakfast, Jesus addresses him directly and asks three times: "Simon, son of John, do you love me?" The three questions naturally recall Peter's three denials, suggesting a deliberate and painful restoration. Peter had already wept over his denial, and the third question now grieves him deeply. He says, "Lord, you know everything; you know that I love you." And each time, Jesus gives him something to do: "Feed my lambs. Tend my sheep. Feed my sheep."

Notice what Jesus does not ask. He does not ask, "Will you try harder?" He does not ask for a five-year plan. He moves beyond bare remorse toward love, responsibility, and renewed following. In this passage, renewed purpose is rooted in relationship with Christ and expressed through loving service. The work does not purchase the relationship; it becomes an expression of it. Love here is not merely an emotion underneath the task; it is the orientation that shapes how the task is carried. And the purpose is given to someone who had just failed, publicly and badly, which means the giving of purpose is not a reward for success.

One safeguard belongs here, because Session Five dealt with serious harm. Peter's restoration does not establish that every person who commits serious misconduct should return to leadership. Forgiveness, fellowship, and usefulness in God's kingdom are not identical to reinstatement in a particular office. Abuse, exploitation, criminal conduct, or serious breaches of trust may permanently disqualify someone from certain roles even where repentance is genuine.

Look also at what the purpose is. "Feed my sheep." It is not a strategy or a title. It is care for people who belong to Jesus. When

the New Testament describes what God's people are for, it consistently comes back to something like this. Jesus, asked for the greatest commandment, gave two: love God with everything, and love your neighbour as yourself (Matthew 22:37–39). **Micah 6:8** says the Lord requires that we "do justice, and love kindness, and walk humbly with your God." **Ephesians 2:10** says believers are "created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them." None of these requires a grand platform. They can begin with a small, proportionate act of faithfulness, sometimes including rest, receiving help, or allowing someone else to carry the work.

I labour this because burnout can change a person's relationship to purpose. Work once experienced as meaningful may become mechanical, compulsory, or emotionally distant. Ministry becomes programmes. Parenting becomes logistics. Care becomes caseload. The experience of love may become harder to feel beneath exhaustion, repetition, conflict, and excessive demands. That does not prove that love has disappeared. Work separated from relationship, meaning, support, and healthy limits can become unbearable weight. But at times faithful duty continues when warm feeling is absent, and that perseverance can itself be an expression of love. If you have been caring for people while feeling nothing, you have not stopped loving them. You may have run out of what love needs to be felt.

Renewing purpose, then, may involve recovering meaning within existing work. It may also involve narrowing the role, sharing it, changing how it is structured, or eventually leaving it after careful discernment. Renewed love cannot make an unsafe or unsustainable structure healthy by itself. Session Seven raised the possibility that some roles need to change for reasons of truth, safety, justice, or health, and Session Three gave you cards for shared and delegated burdens. Purpose renewed is sometimes

purpose narrowed. Peter was told to feed sheep, not to run the world.

Purpose often begins close to home: in loving God, receiving grace, caring for neighbours, practising justice and kindness, using what you have faithfully, and accepting appropriate care yourself. It may include people already within your responsibilities, but it is not limited to being needed by others. Some readers have few dependants, or are between roles, or are recovering from illness, and their purpose in this season may consist largely in receiving. Elijah was fed before he was sent.

A caution about the metaphor. Peter was specifically commissioned to shepherd Christ's people. Most readers should not label others "my sheep"; the phrase can sound possessive, and the specific assignment does not transfer. Ask instead: who currently falls within my legitimate sphere of love, neighbourliness, service, or responsibility? For pastors, "the flock entrusted to your care" may be the right phrase. For everyone else, the principle holds without the label.

One more thing from the passage. It ends with Jesus telling Peter that he will one day be led where he does not want to go, and then two words: "Follow me." Peter's purpose remains inseparable from following Christ. The task is not an independent project; its shape must continue to be tested against the person and way of Jesus. That is true for you as well.

Self-assessment

In your journal:

1. Did your main role once feel meaningful or life-giving? If so, what mattered about it then? If it never did, what originally led you into it?

2. Where has care become emotionally depleted or mechanically performed? Be specific: which tasks, which relationships, which parts of the role.
3. Who is presently within your legitimate sphere of care or responsibility? Who is not?
4. Honestly: if Jesus asked you "Do you love me?" today, what would you say? Write the true answer, including "I am not sure" if that is it. Do not turn this into a test of whether your feelings are intense or pure enough. In Scripture, love includes allegiance, trust, obedience, desire, and return, not uninterrupted emotional warmth.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

Lord, you know everything.

You know what I have loved and how tired I am.

You asked Peter whether he loved you, and then you gave him work.

Ask me. _____.

That is my answer, as honestly as I can give it.

Help me recognise the responsibilities and relationships that are legitimately mine in this season, and the ones I have assumed through fear, pressure, or the need to be indispensable.

Renew love where it has become obscured, and show me where I need rest, support, structural change, grief, or a different form of service.

Where something must narrow or end, show me, and I will test it.

Keep me following you into whatever comes.

Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes, or the length you can manage.

Anchor phrase: **"Lord, you know everything."** Or, if it is honest today: **"Lord, you know that I love you."**

In this silence, sit with the question Jesus asked Peter. Do not answer it in words; you already did in the journal. Simply let it be asked once, and notice what rises: warmth, resistance, grief, longing, nothing. Whatever comes is information, not a verdict. If religious self-checking is compulsive for you, do not repeat the question during the silence; stay with the first anchor phrase instead.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What rose in the silence when the question was asked?
2. Is there a failure that you have treated as proof that grace, growth, or faithful participation are no longer possible? Write it down, and write what this passage says to it. Then, honestly: what restoration may be possible, and what roles may still remain inappropriate or require accountability?
3. Of the people within your care, where has care become depleted? What support, boundary, rest, or small act of attention might help you care more humanely this week?
4. Is any responsibility being sustained mainly by fear, approval-seeking, or the need to prove yourself? What other legitimate reasons remain? Most motives are mixed; mark it for discernment rather than judging it from motive alone.

Practical exercise: a purpose for this season

You are not going to write a mission statement. You are going to answer four questions and then write one sentence, for one season, that fits on an index card.

First, the four questions, briefly, in your journal:

1. Who or what is genuinely within my care?
2. What is outside my responsibility?
3. What does love look like within my present capacity?
4. What support or boundary will make this sustainable? Then the sentence, in this shape or one like it:

In this season, I want to practise love of God and neighbour by _____, within the limits and responsibilities I currently have.

The blank is specific and small. Not "changing the world." Not "reaching my potential." Something like: "by being present with my children in the evenings instead of half-present," or "by preaching to the congregation I have rather than the one I wish I had," or "by caring well for my mother while she is still here," or "by doing my work honestly and going home on time." And for readers whose season is one of receiving: "by attending treatment and allowing others to support me," "by resting while my body heals," "by doing one responsibility faithfully rather than carrying five," or "by being present to God without needing to produce." If you cannot fill the blank with something small, you have not narrowed it enough.

Underneath, write one line beginning **One faithful thing:** and name a single action, doable in the next month, that expresses the sentence. Not a plan. One thing. It should be safe, proportionate, within your control, and compatible with your

current capacity. Rest, asking for help, making an appointment, or declining a non-essential responsibility can count.

Read the card to God. Keep it with the Act, Share, and Seek-counsel cards from Session Three and the identity card from Session Eight. Part Five's 30-day plan will ask you to look at it again on Day 30 and see whether the sentence still fits.

If the exercise surfaced something larger, a sense that a role should end, or change, or that something you have been carrying is not yours, write it on a separate card marked **To test**, and put it with the Session Seven card. It is not a decision. It is a question for the testing that Part Five will walk you through, with the people who can help you weigh it.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

My purpose begins in relationship with Christ, not in proving my worth.
I will practise love within the responsibilities and limits of this season.
What has become unsustainable, I will bring into honest discernment.
I do not have to change the world.
I can take one faithful step.

Notes

Space for anything else you want to record from this session.

After Session Nine: if you are on Day 3, this is the point to stop and rest before Session Ten. You have done as much as the retreat asks and more. If you are doing this after the retreat, put

the card somewhere you will see it. If it is safe and helpful, share the sentence with your support person; speaking it may make it easier to remember, but the exercise remains complete if it stays private. A small, specific purpose is often easier to practise than a grand declaration.